

Document 3: Primary Headaches (Tension and Migraine)

Metadata

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- **Keywords:** headache, migraine, tension headache, head pain, aura

Definition of Primary Headaches

Primary headaches are independent conditions not caused by an underlying disease. The two most common types are tension-type headaches and migraines.

Symptoms of Tension vs. Migraine Headaches

- **Tension Headaches:** Present as a constant, dull ache, often described as a tight band around the head. Pain is usually mild to moderate and affects both sides of the head.
- **Migraine Headaches:** Present as a severe throbbing or pulsing pain, usually on one side of the head. Migraines are often accompanied by nausea, vomiting, and extreme sensitivity to light and sound. Some migraines are preceded by visual disturbances known as auras.

Treatment and Management for Headaches

- **Tension Headaches:** Generally respond well to OTC pain relievers (ibuprofen, acetaminophen, aspirin), stress management, and applying a hot or cold pack to the head or neck.
- **Migraines:** May require prescription medications (triptans, anti-nausea drugs) in addition to OTC pain relievers. Resting in a dark, quiet room is highly recommended during a migraine attack.

When to Seek Medical Attention for Headaches

Immediate emergency care is required for a headache if the patient experiences:

- A sudden, severe headache like a "thunderclap."
- A headache accompanied by fever, stiff neck, confusion, double vision, or numbness/weakness in any part of the body.
- Headaches following a recent head injury.